

ADVANCING GENDER MAINSTREAMING IN THE ENERGY SECTOR





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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

This brief is a synthesis of global and regional social and gender integration framework collated into a report that examines the critical need for gender integration and social inclusion within the energy sector and other organizations. The brief tracks how gender mainstreaming in the energy sector has become a core business driver, not just a policy requirement. Current data shows women hold **32%** of total workforce positions but only **11%** of technical roles, far from the **50%** ECOWAS parity target set for **2030**. The sector is in the "Integration" stage of a transformation model, with key gaps visible in technical employment and supply chain inclusion. The main finding is that closing the gap on technical roles and supplier diversity will unlock the next wave of productivity and innovation gains.

This brief was developed under the leadership of ASEL as part of its commitment to advancing gender mainstreaming in the energy sector. It is informed by the author's participation in the African Women in Energy Regulation Leadership Program, which provided a platform for capacity building, peer learning, and practical engagement on gender integration across Africa.

The insights presented draw on knowledge acquired through the program, complemented by exposure to regional policy frameworks, case studies, and collaborative exchanges with energy professionals and regulators.

Select images included in this brief capture moments from the program and reflect the practical learning experiences that have shaped the perspectives and recommendations outlined in this document.



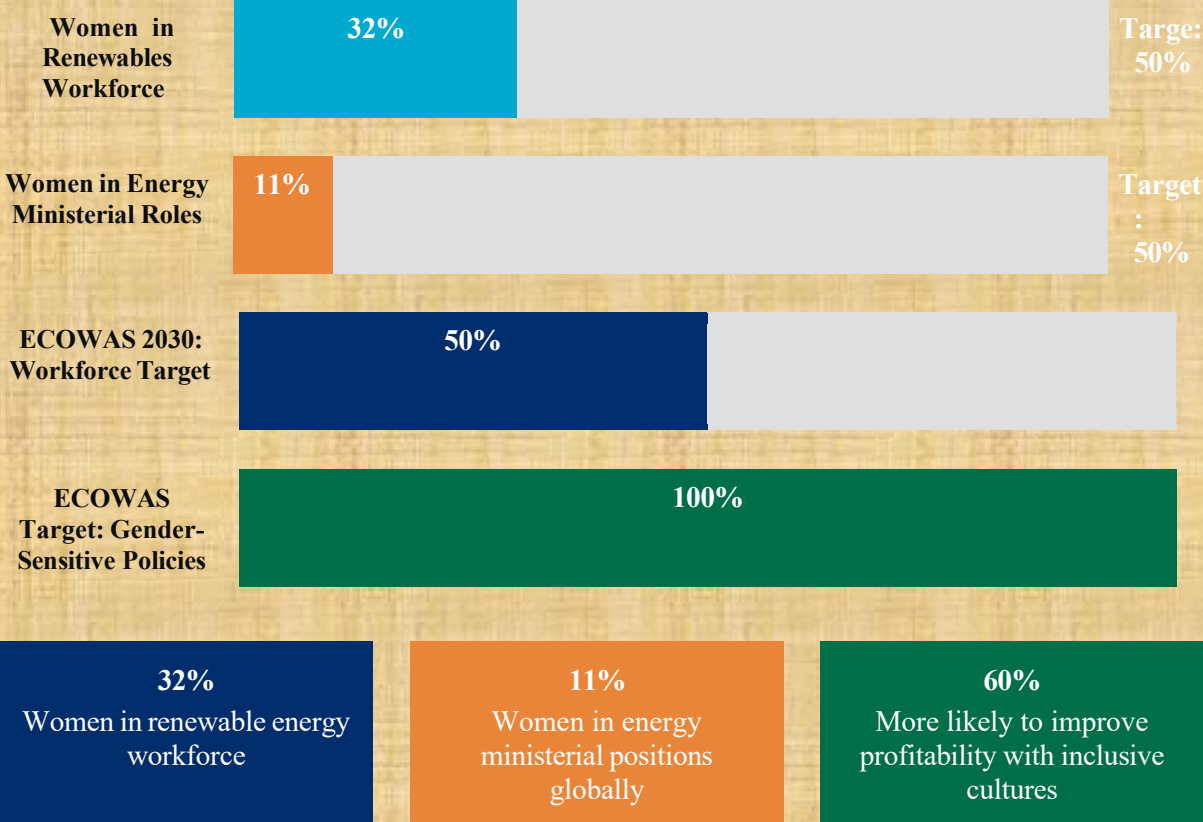




WHY THIS MATTERS NOW

The imperative for gender mainstreaming in the energy sector is no longer purely a social responsibility; it is a critical regulatory and business necessity. Current statistics underscore a profound gap between the sector's present state and its optimal operational potential.

TARGET VS. REALITY: KEY SECTOR METRICS



GLOBAL AND REGIONAL POLICY ARCHITECTURE

Governing frameworks for compliance and strategic alignment

The integration of gender into energy access and regulation is guided by robust legal and advisory frameworks. These documents represent the current standard for compliance and strategic alignment.

FRAMEWORK / DIRECTIVE	CORE MANDATE & IMPLICATIONS
ECOWAS Policy for Gender Mainstreaming in Energy Access (2017)	First regional policy to close gender gaps in West Africa by 2030. Targets 50-50 gender balance in energy workforce; 100% of energy policies gender-sensitive.
ECOWAS Directive on Gender Assessment in Energy Projects (2017)	Legal framework mandating gender assessments and Gender Management Plans for energy projects, ensuring interests of men and women are prioritized during development.
SDG7 Policy Brief: Energy and Gender Equality Interlinkages	UN Technical Advisory Group (TAG) standard indicators measuring progress across clean cooking access, energy entrepreneurship, and technical employment.
UNEP Gender Integration in Renewable Energy Policy Guidelines	Practical steps for policymakers to align renewable strategies with international commitments, notably CEDAW (General Recommendation 37).
NARUC/USAID Practical Guide to Women in Energy Regulation	Details specific barriers and mitigation strategies for women in employment, regulatory policy design, and infrastructure development.
ILO Participatory Gender Audit (PGA) Framework	Organizational change tool examining internal work culture to ensure effective, institutionalized mainstreaming. Addresses structural barriers including overwork culture.

The Organizational Maturity Model

Progress in gender equality is a spectrum. Organizations must systematically assess their current position to guide future interventions.

GENDER-BLIND	GENDER-AWARE	GENDER-RESPONSIVE	GENDER-TRANSFORMATIVE
→	→	→	★
Ignores gender differences entirely. Policies assume interventions affect all identically. Data is aggregated.	Acknowledges differences exist. Recognizes women face unique barriers, but operations remain largely unchanged.	Addresses different needs directly. Implements targeted policies: flexible hours, sex-disaggregated data.	Actively changes negative norms and institutional behaviors. Dismantles structural barriers for lasting equity.

From compliance to competitive advantage

Gender mainstreaming evolves through three distinct phases, each unlocking greater organizational value:

COMPLIANCE FOCUS	OPERATIONAL INTEGRATION	COMPETITIVE ADVANTAGE
• Meeting ECOWAS directive baselines • Avoiding regulatory penalties • Basic anti-discrimination policies	• Executing Social & Gender Integration Plans • Utilizing all-women teams for loss reduction • Tracking sex-disaggregated data	• 60% higher likelihood of improved profitability • Expanded customer base targeting specific needs • Resilient, innovative supply chains

INTEGRATING GENDER MAINSTREAMING IN COMPANIES TO DRIVE OUTCOMES

Four operational levers for transformative change

Utilities and private energy developers can drastically improve their financial viability, innovation, and resilience by weaving gender mainstreaming into the core operational fabric.

1. Developing a Social and Gender Integration Plan (SGIP)

Companies must adopt an SGIP as an operational document to monitor and enforce inclusion objectives.

- **Problem Identification:** Conduct rigorous needs assessments and gender analyses for all new projects prior to financial close.
- **Actionable Pathways:** Define clear operational responsibilities, assign dedicated timelines, and ring-fence budgets for gender-specific activities.

2. Human Resource (HR) Lifecycle Interventions

Building a diverse workforce requires focus across the entire HR continuum, transcending simple recruitment.

- **Recruitment:** Implement gender-neutral job descriptions and mandate Rooney Rule-style candidate slate requirements to ensure diverse shortlists.
- **Retention and Advancement:** Offer flexible work schedules, comprehensive parental leave, and childcare stipends to structurally support work-life balance.
- **Workplace Protections:** Enforce strict anti-harassment and anti-discrimination policies to secure a physically and psychologically safe environment.

3. Operational and Revenue Improvements

Mainstreaming gender generates direct impacts on corporate bottom lines and operational efficiency.

- **Customer Base Expansion:** Improve utility financial viability by targeting women's specific energy needs for productive uses (agricultural milling, cooling).
- **Loss Reduction:** Deploy all-women teams for meter reading and payment collection evidence shows this increases receptivity among female customers and improves timeliness of bill collection.
- **Inclusive Procurement:** Set mandatory thresholds for women-owned or gender-certified businesses in the corporate supply chain, driving community economic growth.

4. Data-Driven Decision Making

Organizations must transition structurally from gender-blind to gender-sensitive data governance.

- **Sex-Disaggregated Data:** Collect and parse data separately for women and men regarding energy usage patterns, consumption habits, and grid connection rates.
- **Impact Monitoring:** Utilize strict gender indicators to measure whether project outcomes successfully reach female-headed households, who often lack collateral for upfront connection fees.



CONDUCTING A PARTICIPATORY GENDER AUDIT

Companies should periodically undergo an ILO-style Participatory Gender Audit (PGA). This social audit establishes an evidence-based baseline, documents internal good practices, and systematically propels the company toward Gender Transformative actions that permanently alter negative institutional behaviors.

IMPLEMENTATION ROADMAP

A phased approach ensuring smooth integration, capability building, and sustainable results

HORIZON	FOCUS AREA	KEY MILESTONES
HORIZON 1 FOUNDATION	Governance & Baseline	› Launch ILO-style Participatory Gender Audit › Draft and approve initial Social & Gender Integration Plan (SGIP) › Update HR recruitment guidelines (gender-neutral JDs, diverse slates)
HORIZON 2 INTEGRATION	Operations & Data	› Implement sex-disaggregated data collection for new connections › Pilot all-women meter reading and collection teams › Revise procurement policies to set supplier diversity thresholds
HORIZON 3 TRANSFORMATION	Scale & Culture	› Achieve interim workforce gender parity targets › Full integration of Gender Management Plans in all capital projects › Report outcomes against SDG7 interlinkage metrics

KPI FOR BOARD-LEVEL MONITORING

Standardized, high-level metrics evaluated quarterly

CATEGORY	KEY PERFORMANCE INDICATORS (KPIs) — Monitored Quarterly
WORKFORCE	% of total workforce that is female (Target: 50%) % of executive and technical roles held by women Female vs. male employee retention rate
OPERATIONS	Number of active all-women operational teams Revenue recovery rate linked to inclusive field interventions
CUSTOMER IMPACT	% of new grid connections to female-headed households Growth in electricity for productive uses by women (milling, cooling)
SUPPLY CHAIN	% of procurement spend to women-owned enterprises
GOVERNANCE	% of capital projects with approved Gender Management Plan Completion status of bi-annual Participatory Gender Audit

KEY RECOMMENDATIONS FOR LEADERSHIP

Six strategic imperatives for energy sector executives

01 Mandate SGIPs on All Projects

Require a formal Social and Gender Integration Plan prior to project approval and capital allocation.

02 Re-engineer the HR Lifecycle

Enforce diverse candidate slates and introduce comprehensive work-life benefits tailored to retention.

03 Capitalize on Inclusive Operations

Deploy diverse field teams to enhance collection efficiency, lower non-technical losses, and build community trust.

04 Upgrade Data Architecture

Transition immediately to collecting and analyzing sex-disaggregated customer and operational data.

05 Stimulate Local Economies

Integrate mandatory gender thresholds within the corporate procurement supply chain.

06 Commit to the PGA Process

Conduct routine Participatory Gender Audits to transition corporate culture from compliance-oriented to genuinely transformative.

CONCLUSION

The energy sector is at a pivotal inflection point. Historically male-dominated structures are proving inadequate against modern demands for innovation, community integration, and operational efficiency. By shifting gender mainstreaming from an abstract policy goal to a core corporate operational strategy, utilities and developers in Africa will not only achieve compliance with ambitious ECOWAS targets, they will unlock new paradigms of profitability and societal impact.



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